“this was a golden country, that you could sleep under every bush, that concealing the missiles would not require much work.” Pliev, Statsenko, Garbuz, Burlov, and the others who arrived in July found the heat overwhelming, the humidity debilitating, and the landscape unforgiving.[20]

The reconnaissance teams soon found that small palm groves could not conceal the more than 20-meter-long missiles, while the larger forests impeded the free movement of air: given the heat and humidity, rocket equipment produced for the European theater was prone to malfunction. There were also poisonous plants that the Soviets had never encountered and whose ill effects they could not counteract effectively. The locations mapped by the Biriuzov group simply proved unsuitable. Statsenko later reported on the activities and findings of his group: “The areas where the General Staff had directed the regiments to deploy were surveyed four times by means of helicopter flights. The western and central parts of the island of Cuba were surveyed from helicopters, and it was determined that the areas assigned to the regiments of Comrades Sidorov, Cherkesov, and Bandilovsky had very broken terrain, little vegetation, and a poorly developed road network; hence they are poorly suited for the deployment of rocket regiments.”[21]

The Soviet personnel had to start from scratch, looking for new locations. The Cubans put forward their own requirements: no area selected for the deployment of missiles could exceed 1,100 acres in size, and the number of families to be resettled was not to exceed six or eight. With the help of their Cuban hosts, the Soviet teams surveyed more than 150 locations on a territory in excess of 9,000 square kilometers and chose ten areas that more or less met their requirements but still provided no reliable cover from American reconnaissance planes. Each of the five regiments was supposed to be assigned two areas for its launchers. Aided by small engineering detachments, they immediately began preparing positions for the missiles, which were to arrive on the island in early September.

One of the unpleasant discoveries they made right away was that none of the bridges across Cuban rivers was strong enough to support the weight of the Soviet trucks and missiles to be moved to the designated areas. “The division commander often found himself obliged to make nontraditional decisions, especially pouring concrete into riverbeds so that they could be